

[Return to Search](#)

Life-crisis rituals among the Kenuz

Author(S): Callender, Charles, El Guindi, Fadwa

Document Type: Book

Original Page: 67

Culture (OWC): [Nubians \(MR08\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Northern Africa

Field Date: 1962-1963

Coverage Date: 1962 AD - 1963 AD

Place Coverage: Northern Aswan Governate, Egypt

Section Title(S): MARRIAGE TO SEBU

Yet there are discernable traces of such a connection. An elderly informant described the ostensible purpose of agilbaygit as inducing the bride to undress. A younger man recalled that when his wife came on the first night she wore nothing under her shogga, which she removed after he gave her money. FG, interviewing a young married woman whose mother was present, unexpectedly found that the latter was closely questioning her about the marriage practices followed by Egyptians in Cairo. Really shocked to learn that women there did not demand agilbaygit, she expressed her feelings forcefully, "Your mother bears you and nurses you, and then you give your cunt to a man without asking him for money! You should be ashamed, ashamed for the milk your mother gave you. You should never give yourself without money. Sleeping with a man is expensive." The connection between agilbaygit and sexual rights seems quite explicit in this statement. Nevertheless, its nature had apparently become covertly symbolic rather than direct.

[124](#)
[Interviewing In](#)
[Research](#)

[431](#)
[Gift Giving](#)

[576](#)
[Etiquette](#)

[585](#)
[Nuptials](#)

[831](#)
[Sexuality](#)

[833](#)
[Sexual Intercourse](#)

Grooms also had to pay the women who performed services for them after the wedding. The actions undertaken by their mothers or sisters were viewed as obligations that did not require compensation. But other women who brought a groom his meals and his bath water, like those who escorted the bride to his room each night, were paid. If several women shared one of these roles, he usually gave each of them a small amount at the time, usually ten piastres. Any woman who consistently waited on him received a larger amount, about £E 1, when her services ended with the sebu.

[431](#)
[Gift Giving](#)

[576](#)
[Etiquette](#)

[585](#)
[Nuptials](#)

[890](#)

Gender Roles And
Issues

All informants agreed that intercourse never occurred in Dahmit on the wedding night, and that it should not take place on the night that followed. Otherwise their statements were very contradictory. Their disagreements probably reflected recent changes in practice. Like other aspects of Kenuz culture, the customs of the migrants involving marriage had diverged considerably from those followed in Dahmit. These changes had inevitably begun to affect practices within the district, but its residents, as individuals, varied greatly in their acceptance of these.

124
Interviewing In
Research585
Nuptials833
Sexual Intercourse

As far as we can reconstruct the earlier form, consummation was postponed until after the sebu, although some sexual play occurred before that day. Some accounts suggest that defloration and consummation were distinct acts, occurring on different days. Others describe these as the same event. The marriage was consummated during the day, and in the presence of several women. These included the groom's mother, two women representing the bride, who could stand in any relationship to her except that of mother, and a midwife. The bride's relatives held her during the act and, like the groom's mother, were witnesses to her virginity. The midwife directed the groom. Some informants said that intercourse was sometimes impossible until she had enlarged the vagina by cutting through the scar tissue resulting from excision. Apparently the blood proving the bride's status as a virgin was viewed only by the women who attended the consummation, without a public showing comparable to that practiced by peasant groups in Egypt.

304
Body Alterations585
Nuptials832
Sexual Stimulation833
Sexual Intercourse836
Premarital Sex
Relations890
Gender Roles And
Issues

Joking and horseplay were also prominent features of the days before the sebu. The women charged with bringing a bride to her husband on the night after their wedding sometimes substituted a boy, whom they had wrapped in a shogga. One informant was ready to pay agilbaygit when the boy's giggles aroused his suspicions. Women eavesdropped on newly-married couples, particularly on their first night, trying to learn how much time elapsed before the bride spoke, and what her first words were. The room where the groom lived was formerly built shortly before the wedding, and was temporarily roofed with palm branches laid across its walls. Young men used to climb up to push these aside and spy on the pair. They also tried to steal the couples' slippers, which were left outside the door at night—noiselessly slipping up to the door for this purpose, or standing outside the courtyard wall with a fishing rod and hook. If they succeeded, the groom had to give them pigeons as ransom before they would return the slippers. The arosoki was supposed to be on guard against all such activities.

343
Outbuildings522
Humor585
Nuptials832
Sexual Stimulation833
Sexual Intercourse883
Adolescent Activities890
Gender Roles And
Issues

Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries:  hraf@yale.edu

Issues and Bugs:  hraf-support@yale.edu



[Terms and Conditions](#) · [Accessibility](#) · [Cookie Policy](#)